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From the editor-in-chief

The INDIA TODAY State of the States Report has, over its seven years, grown to become an independent and extremely credible assessment of the functioning of government. States, their governments and ruling political parties are rated and ranked on their performance over the last year across a range of sectors like infrastructure, health, agriculture, investment, education and consumer markets, strictly on statistical performance data.

We are particularly proud that in the age of Twitter and attention-deficit demographics, the INDIA TODAY State of the States Report remains committed to being objective, in-depth and substantive about issues that make a difference on the ground—the execution and impact of official policy. In what was a powerful echo of reinforcement, voters at the last general elections chose to ignore caste, communal and populist themes and voted largely on the performance of parties and candidates.

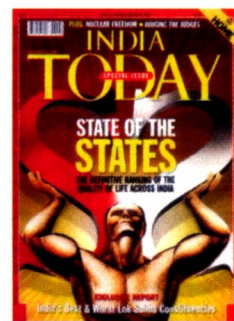
This year we have created two separate categories of study and awards: one, of performance of states across eight categories since 2003, the first year of high growth, and the other on how efficiently money meant for the poor is spent. As inclusive growth is the Government's favourite chant, we decided to test whether the states are in tune in the areas of NREGA, rural roads, irrigation, housing for the poor, rural electrification, drinking water and e-governance.

The results of this year's State of the States Report reflect a dynamic shift. Punjab, which has been the best state for six years, is now challenged on every front. Hill state Himachal Pradesh is the new emerging star among big states. Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra, Karnataka and Uttarakhand are among the most improved states in investment, consumer markets, governance and education. Kerala, once the economists' own country in health and education, faces a stiff challenge in both sectors from Himachal Pradesh.

Most significantly, the north-eastern states, often forgotten by the mainstream, are in fact showing the way to the rest of the country in social sectors. Many of the larger states should pay attention and learn from them. Sadly, even though there are many signs of hope, there is tremendous despair in the fact that states with large populations and rich resources like Bihar, West Bengal and Orissa have done little to change their circumstances. The names of the winners did come as a surprise and it was heartening to note that there was more than one state that ended up performing higher than its potential. The key difference between Underperformers and Outperformers was in the quality of governance.

The Seventh INDIA TODAY State of the States Report and the state awards were presented at a day-long conclave in the capital which produced healthy debate between Central ministers and representatives of as many as 16 states. Our cover package this week, put together by Managing Editor Shankkar Aiyar, is a reflection of just what occupies the mind of government during difficult economic times. The demand for higher standards of governance at all levels, to our mind, is always the best place to begin.

(Aroon Purie)



OUR SEPT 2008 STATE OF THE STATES COVER